

Transformations, Substitutions, and Reversals: Kafka

In the text *Postwar: A History of Europe since 1945*, historian Tony Judt describes what he called a feeling of despair in the interwar period as the continent edged closer and closer to the abyss. Something had been lost in the events that imploded Europe with the start of World War I, but this did not in fact end with the ceasing of fighting. Indeed, something continued to rot at Europe within the core, but the implications of this rot were, according to Judt, long since intuited by the likes of Franz Kafka, whose anticipation to the events to come was “embarrassingly penetrating” (Judt, 438).

Kafka, whose literary feats range from realistic fictional works to more surrealist stories to even his own personal thoughts and diary entries, was writing in a time where identity was of the utmost concern, and not only apparent to the Jewish question (which Kafka thought extensively on) but also regarding the economic circumstances, family relations, and existential debacle that plagued the minds of Europeans. This led to the development of a multitude of texts which addressed the themes of the body, such as size, health, cleanliness, and age, as well as the subject of transformation and role reversal. For example, these ideas become intertwined in the case of “The Judgement” and “The Metamorphosis” in that they all embody the common thread of transformation, at least in appearance. I say this because the role of transformation, which one might think would signify a dynamic change, is in truth a façade in these texts. By this, I mean that it becomes painfully obvious that any signal of change, which is often framed as the good kind of change, is at best a feint by Kafka who is hiding an upsetting yet apparent secret, which

is that despite the appearance of change, within the body and without, the message of these texts is ultimately one of static. In the same way that Europeans were outwardly convinced of the continent's stability, that it had undergone a radical change with the war and moved beyond the capacity for that kind of violence again, the characters of these texts are initially content with their lives as they are. But despite their efforts to continue living, some kind of grievance that arose prior to the narrative remains, and it catches up to these characters in various ways.

Perhaps the most realistic among the three texts, "The Judgement" begins with an explicit reference to the setting. It was on a "Sunday morning at the height of spring" when the protagonist, Georg was finishing a letter to a friend who was abroad (Kafka, 232). Immediately, the reader is given the impression of new beginnings with the start of a new week in the season that represents fertility, procreation, and life. Continuing, Kafka writes from the perspective of Georg who is currently engaged in a deeply introspective exercise on the circumstances of his friend. While he begins by thinking on the events which led to his friend emigrating to Russia and describes in a matter-of-fact tone his stagnating business (Kafka, 232), this lighthearted pondering quickly becomes somewhat grave. Not only that, Georg's thoughts become noticeably more enraptured with himself as he thinks more on the topic, reminiscing on the effects of his mother's death on his father's distant attitude with the family business and a reality where he had listened to his friend's advice and moved to Russia himself to expand the business (Kafka, 234). However, Georg has this moment where he snaps back to the present by affirming his current attitude with this friend, which is confined to him writing these letters detailing the most "insignificant events such as the ones that heap themselves up in his memory when reflecting on a quiet Sunday" (Kafka, 234). He literally expresses his intention to leave "undisturbed" the

image of his friend which he has somewhat concocted in his own psyche, regardless of how accurate it is because that is the only way for him to “reconcile” with its existence.

It is at this point that the reader becomes increasingly aware of the strangely cold opinion that Georg has toward his supposed companion. It is evident in the way that Georg must practically convince *himself* that the attitude he holds toward this friend is justified. For example, Georg admits that he holds a lot of conversations about his friend with his fiancé, Frieda Brandenfeld, but one of those conversations is noticeably peculiar in the way it devolves into an examination of Georg’s thinking. When questioned on whether the friend will be invited to their wedding, Georg insists that it would be better if he didn’t bother him and reasons that if he did, his friend would “envy him and leave surely dissatisfied and unable to rid himself of the feeling” (Kafka, 234). At this point, it is unclear whether or not Georg really had this conversation with his fiancé as she tells Georg that if he really felt this way about his friend, maybe it would have been better if he stayed unmarried, or to put it another way, stayed a bachelor just like the friend. In response, Georg insists that he wouldn’t have it any other way, and essentially talks himself into finishing the letter in the most aloof way possible. He argues that his friend ought to accept him the way he currently is, and that he can’t “cut a person” out of himself who might be more suited to friendship than “he” himself is. Here, by addressing the person who is friends with this abroad companion as a separate entity, Georg is confirming the detached relationship he has with this mysterious person. It is not Georg himself who is friends with this man, but another version of him who, at best, might be trapped in Georg’s past and has failed to catch up with the present and, at worst, might have never existed to begin with.

Undoubtedly, the nail in the coffin for “The Judgement” is when we are introduced to the character of Georg’s father. In short, he is the one to break the long drawn-out illusion to his son

in the most violent way possible. When Georg attempts to shift the matter to his father's health, it is his way of reducing his father's power and subsequently the hold he has demonstrated over Georg all his life. However, his father is not a man who goes down easily. The first time around, his father straightly insists that "you have no friend in St. Petersburg and you've always been a joker" (Kafka, 237). And though Georg manages to ignore this comment and continues to wheel his father into his bed, tacitly condemning him to a deathly fate, this victory is short-lived. By evoking the image of a vengeful spirit returning from death, Kafka paints Georg final encounter with his father as this strangely cathartic moment. His father now acknowledges the existence of his son's friend, but only via the description that he "would have been a son after [his] own heart" (Kafka, 239). Here, it is almost confirmed that when Georg has been deceiving his St. Petersburg friend, he has simultaneously been deceiving himself, and when his father claims to be weeping for his St. Petersburg friend, he in truth has been mourning the severance with his one true son. The fact of the matter is that Georg had never been fond of his father. That is the reason why every time he views him, we get the perspective of a man observing a rather pitiful figure: a giant man in a fluttering gown bearing a toothless smile whom he wishes death upon more openly as the resolution nears. As previously mentioned, we as the audience are made unaware to the explicit details of the conflict which has occurred outside the context of the story, but Kafka provides us with enough hints to catch us up to speed. In "The Judgement" it is known that at least three years have passed since the "friend" left for Russia, at which point "he was already yellow enough to be thrown away" (Kafka, 241) but even before that point it is noted that Georg mother's couldn't live to see that day.

Regarding the end of the story, it feels like an opportune moment to connect the conclusions of "The Judgement" with that of "The Metamorphosis", for these are the points

where the readers' expectations are most subverted. In the endings of both these stories, a son has died. In the former, he is sentenced to a watery grave. In the latter, he simply succumbs to his weakening body. However, and though it is less apparent in "The Judgement", there is never a moment in either of these texts where it is clear to the reader that we must move on. It is at these points that the development of these texts become spiral-like, alluding to some kind of ending but never gaining any distance from the beginning. With Georg, Kafka makes the effort to begin an entirely new paragraph for one observation: "At that moment, a positively endless stream of traffic was going over the bridge." By shifting the narrative to a scene that one otherwise wouldn't think much about, Kafka has made it clear how insignificant Georg's death is. In the eyes of a world that never stops to look, Georg was just another unfortunate soul overburdened by any number of arbitrary grievances. They will never hear his side of the story with his father nor understand the emotional baggage he carried for so long.

In "The Metamorphosis" that burden is instead passed down to Gregor's sister, Grete Samsa, in the final passage of the text. Here, though Gregor's death happens earlier in the text than it did for Georg, it is similarly anticlimactic in its description and empty in tone. Showing no indications of grief, the family quickly inspects the corpse of their son before discussing their plans for the future. And though the three of them believe they all had something to gain with this occasion, the attention shifts to the daughter through a quick perspective change to that of Herr and Frau Samsa. To put it another way, it is now Grete who is treated as this "other" figure in the eyes of the patriarch and the matriarch. She has inherited the role of her late brother and now it is her bodily features which garner the narrative's attention. She "was growing ever more vivacious...beautiful...voluptuous" (Kafka, 47). Furthermore, it is noted how the parents have begun to communicate with one another almost telepathically at this point, "growing quieter"

and signaling “by an exchange of glances.” This further lends credence to the way the parents had isolated Gregor and have already begun to do the same to Grete. Hence, the theme of the oedipal replacement is not only an argument for the unchanging nature of the family, but also a specific criticism of the family as an extension to the system of exploitation, one that will alienate the labor of the worker, which is indicated by Gregor’s frustration when he is denied essentials such as food (Kafka, 35) despite being directly responsible for the wellbeing of his exploiters. But where the man’s value came from his ability to serve as breadwinner or to perform economic reproduction, the woman’s value is connected to her ability to be a good wife or to perform social reproduction. What is even more tragic is that there’s a possibility that a similar metamorphosis will happen to Grete if she loses the traits which society has deemed desirable, and it becomes the next generation’s duty to perform in the cycle.

In both cases of “The Judgement” and “The Metamorphosis”, the death of the son also signifies an apparent role reversal in the story. Despite being in the presence of their fathers, who are now bumbling old men that Georg and Gregor are forced to accommodate, the protagonists end up as the characters not only dead but dying relatively young. It’s almost as if by simply staying within the vicinity, the sons are drained of their own life force to prolong the lives of their fathers. That being said, the rationale for this phenomena isn’t mystical or supernatural in any way, but plainly the result of the teleological relationship that put these characters down their paths. Working backwards, we have previously established that the breakdown between Georg and his father was an ongoing process that had been hinted at throughout “The Judgement.” Likewise, one could have hypothesized the ending to “The Metamorphosis” through similar observations. For example, one of the first things that struck me as a reader was the relatively tame attitude that Gregor’s family held upon discovering his transformation. Although they are

stunned by the first encounter (Kafka, 16), their attitude quickly devolves into resentment as they become annoyed more than anything over the change. Though this obviously played a role in catering to Kafka's absurdist style (the fact that no one at any point began to question why this was happening) this choice becomes a much more deliberate element of social commentary as the story nears its end. In all honesty, the transformation becomes less and less relevant as the family becomes more and more concerned with the practical disadvantages they must deal with. By the end of the text, one could genuinely posit that the story could have happened the same way absent the entire metamorphosis. In an alternate rendition where Gregor simply became a cripple, the attitude of his parasitic family would seldom change.

Alas, we as the readers were presented with two tales where the endings, in their own unique fashion, were set in stone from the very start, but only now do we realize that we've been taken on this very long round trip by the likes of Franz Kafka.